WHITE PAPER · VERSION 3.0

How Much Notice AI Vendors Give on Price and Model Changes

Lead Times on Rate Increases, Rate Decreases, New Pricing Elements and Retirements, June 2025 to October 2026

> How many days first-party AI model vendors give between announcing a change and the day it takes effect, measured from 44 verified events across 11 vendors' own pages.

95.5	31.5	0
MEDIAN DAYS, RETIREMENTS	MEDIAN DAYS, INCREASES	MEDIAN DAYS, DECREASES

Jerry W. Lambert, Sr.

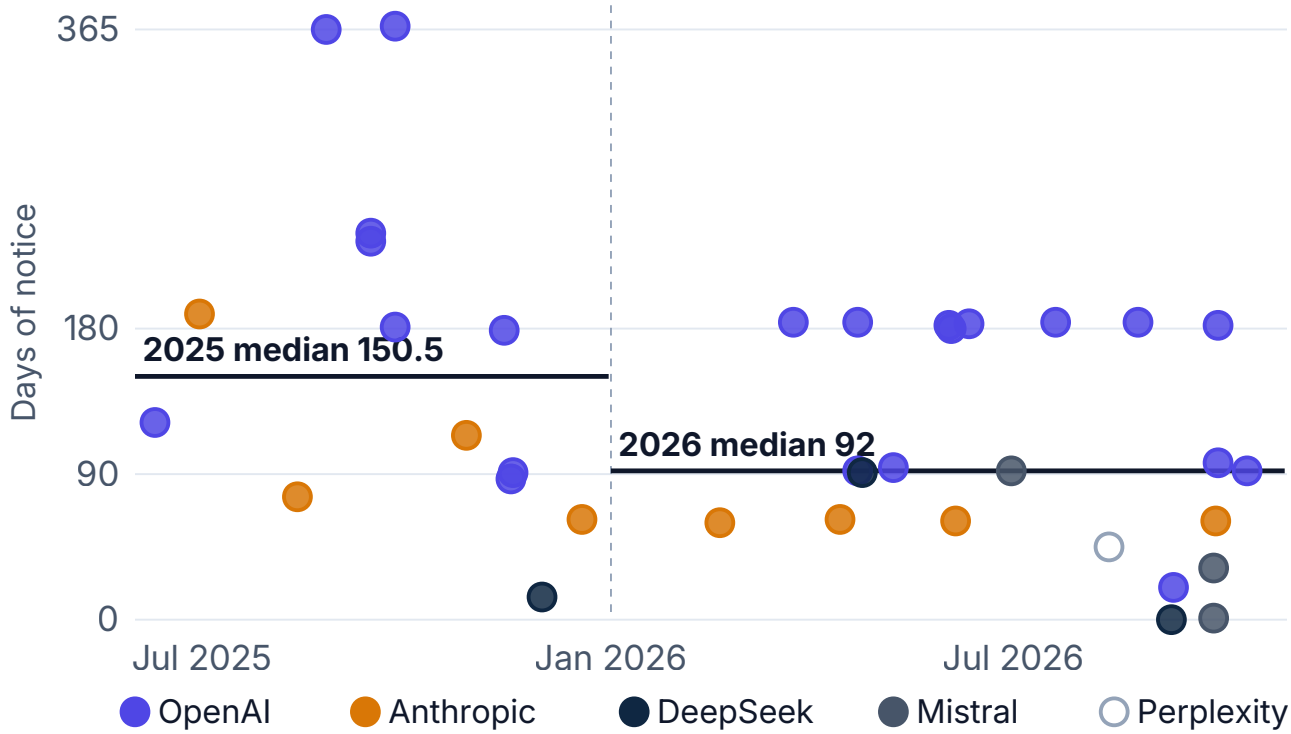
October 24, 2026 · jerrywlambert.com

Retirement Notice Is Shrinking

Vendors are giving less notice before they retire a model. Across the 37 dated retirement announcements in my data, the 14 made in 2025 got a median of 150.5 days. The 23 made in 2026 so far got a median of 92 days.

150.5	92	367 / 184
2025 MEDIAN DAYS (14 EVENTS)	2026 MEDIAN DAYS (23 EVENTS)	LONGEST NOTICE, 2025 / 2026

DAYS OF NOTICE BY ANNOUNCEMENT DATE



Each dot is one retirement announcement (rows 15 to 51 of the event table). The black lines are the median for each announcement year. The hollow Perplexity dot is its Sonar sunset (45 days), labeled PROXY ANNOUNCE because its announcement date is my first sighting, an upper bound. I include it in the 37 events and the 2026 median here. It is not one of the 36 verified retirements in the category statistics later in this report. Removing it leaves the 2026 median at 92.

VENDOR BY VENDOR

- **Anthropic.** claude-3-opus, announced Jun 30, 2025, got 189 days. claude-3-7-sonnet, announced Oct 28, 2025, got 114. Every Claude retirement announced after that got 60 to 62 days (five events), right at Anthropic's stated 60-day floor.
- **OpenAI.** In 2025 OpenAI gave 365 days on the Assistants API and 367 days on legacy GPT snapshots. No 2026 announcement comes close. Its 2026 notices cluster near 90 days (92 to 97) or near 180 days (180 to 184). The exception is gpt-5.4-cyber at 20 days.

- **Mistral.** mistral-ocr-4-0 got 1 day, deprecated Sep 29 and retired Sep 30, 2026.
- **DeepSeek.** deepseek-v4-flash got zero notice. DeepSeek retired it on Sep 10, 2026, the day it announced the change, and routed the names to V4.1-Flash.

HOW I READ IT

I read this as a deliberate move by the vendors. Shorter notice gives customers less time on older models, which tend to cost less than the models vendors want them on. Intent is not observable in this data. What the data shows is the shorter notice. The pricing of the retired models is not part of this study either, so the cheaper-model point is my interpretation.

> Caveats. Only 37 dated events. OpenAI accounts for 22 of the 37. The 2026 figures cover about 10 months, and the latest announcement in the data is Oct 14, 2026.

What This Means for Anyone Buying AI

AI vendors change the terms of the bill constantly, and they are giving buyers less time to react. That leaves buyers with two needs.

1. A Charge Record Nobody Can Rewrite

The scale of the churn is documented. The companion report, The 28 Ways AI Models Charge, counts 28 distinct billing mechanisms across 106 models from 18 vendors. This report adds 44 verified dated events between June 2025 and October 2026: 4 rate increases, 2 rate decreases, 2 new pricing elements and 36 retirements. Some took effect the day they were announced.

When the price list moves that often, a monthly invoice cannot be trusted on its face. A buyer needs a record of every charge that cannot be altered after the fact and can be checked against the dated Tariff in force when the call ran. Each line should show the model, the units, the price applied and the Tariff date it came from. That record needs an attestation, a signed statement that it is complete and unchanged, so a finance team or an auditor can confirm it without taking anyone's word for it.

2. The Freedom to Move Work Between Vendors

The second need follows from the trend, though the data does not prove the cost effect. The logic runs like this. If vendors retire older models faster, which the data shows, and buyers must move to the replacement, and the replacement costs more per unit of work, and the buyer does not or cannot switch to a cheaper option at another vendor, then the buyer's cost per unit of work rises over time.

The third condition is not established here. This report does not compare the prices of retired models with the prices of their replacements. Price per token is also only part of the cost. Anthropic says Claude 4.7 and later use a tokenizer that "produces approximately 30% more tokens for the same text," so the same work can cost more even at an unchanged per-token price.

The fourth condition is the one a buyer controls. A buyer who can move work between vendors without rewiring an application can chase the best price per unit of capability. A buyer wired to one vendor takes whatever that vendor's next retirement notice brings, on that vendor's schedule.

> **MY VIEW**
>
> It is a mistake for a consumer to lock themselves into one vendor.

Executive Summary

I wanted to know how much warning AI model vendors give before a change hits my bill. I counted the days between the date a vendor printed an announcement and the date the change took effect. I found 44 verified events from 43 distinct announcements between June 2025 and October 2026. One DeepSeek repricing on August 13, 2026 counts twice, once as a rate increase and once as a new pricing element.

The answer depends on the kind of change. Model retirements get the most notice, with a median of 95.5 days across 36 events. Rate increases get weeks to months, with a median of 31.5 days across 4 events. New pricing elements get days to two weeks, with a median of 8.5 days across 2 events. Rate decreases took effect the day they were announced in both verified cases.

OpenAI is the most predictable vendor. Its median retirement notice is 181.5 days, and it publishes a 6-month policy for GA models. DeepSeek and Mistral run the shortest clocks. DeepSeek gave 3 days on a repricing that added peak-hour rates and 0 days on a retirement. Mistral gave 1 day on an OCR model retirement.

The first three categories have 2 to 4 events each. Read those numbers as indicative, not as a rule. Retirements have 36 events and give a firmer picture.

Notice by Category, in Days

CATEGORY	EVENTS	MIN	MEDIAN	MAX	RANGE	ZERO-NOTICE
Rate increases	4	3	31.5	121	118	0
Rate decreases	2	0	0	0	0	2
New pricing elements	2	3	8.5	14	11	0
Deprecations and retirements	36	0	95.5	367	367	1

Small samples. Rate increases have 4 events, rate decreases 2 and new pricing elements 2. Retirements have 36. Excluded and unverified events are listed under each category and never enter the statistics.

1. Rate Increases

4	3	31.5	121	118
EVENTS	MIN DAYS	MEDIAN DAYS	MAX DAYS	RANGE DAYS

Small sample: 4 verified events. Read these numbers as indicative.

Four verified increases range from 3 days to 121 days of notice. Three of the four are the scheduled end of launch pricing. The vendor prints the end date on day one, so the notice is real, but it is easy to forget.

BY VENDOR (DAYS OF NOTICE)

VENDOR	EVENTS	MIN	MEDIAN	MAX
DeepSeek	1	3	3	3
Google	2	49	85	121
Mistral	1	14	14	14

NOTABLE EXAMPLES

- **Google gemini-3.8-flash.** Google printed the intro price of 0.75/3.75 USD per 1M tokens at GA on Sep 2, 2026. It steps to 1.50/7.50 on Jan 1, 2027. That is 121 days, the longest increase notice I found.
- **Google gemini-4-argon.** Announced Oct 13 and effective Dec 1, 2026, 49 days. The price moves moving from 2.00/10.00 to 4.00/20.00.
- **Mistral Large 4.** The 50 percent launch sale ended Oct 20, 2026, 14 days after the Oct 6 announcement. List price is 1.36/4.18.
- **DeepSeek V4-Pro.** The Aug 13, 2026 change log announced peak and off-peak pricing effective 16:00 UTC on Aug 16, 3 days later. Off-peak input rose from 0.435 to 0.66 USD per 1M, and a new peak rate of 1.32 appeared.

EXCLUDED FROM THE STATISTICS (3)

VENDOR	EVENT	LABEL	WHY
Z.ai	GLM-5.3-Flash 50% promo ends (list 0.15/0.50)	PROXY ANNOUNCE	Page undated. Announcement date is my first sighting, an upper bound (11 days). Ends 24:00 UTC+8 Sep 9.
Google	gemini-3.6-flash intro ends, 0.75/3.75 to 1.50/7.50	PROXY ANNOUNCE	Announcement date not printed. First sighting gives 93 days.

VENDOR	EVENT	LABEL	WHY
Anthropic	Claude Sonnet 5 planned Sep 1 rise, 2/10 to 3/15 (cancelled)	UNVERIFIED ANNOUNCE	Announcement date unverified. Cancelled before it took effect.

2. Rate Decreases

2	0	0	0	0
EVENTS	MIN DAYS	MEDIAN DAYS	MAX DAYS	RANGE DAYS

Small sample: 2 verified events. Read these numbers as indicative.

Both verified decreases took effect the day the vendor announced them. Vendors have no reason to delay a cut, so this is the pattern I expect, but two events is a thin sample.

BY VENDOR (DAYS OF NOTICE)

VENDOR	EVENTS	MIN	MEDIAN	MAX
Anthropic	1	0	0	0
DeepSeek	1	0	0	0

NOTABLE EXAMPLES

- **Anthropic.** The Oct 7, 2026 release notes cut the claude-sonnet-5-5 cache read price from 0.20 to 0.10 USD per 1M, effective the same day.
- **DeepSeek.** V4.1-Flash launched on Sep 10, 2026 with reduced prices (off-peak 0.15/0.60), effective the same day.

EXCLUDED FROM THE STATISTICS (1)

VENDOR	EVENT	LABEL	WHY
OpenAI	gpt-5.6-sol short-context promo, 5/30 to 4/20 (through at least 2026-11-21)	UNVERIFIED ANNOUNCE	Effective 2026-08-21. Announcement date not found on a first-party page.

3. New Pricing Elements

2	3	8.5	14	11
EVENTS	MIN DAYS	MEDIAN DAYS	MAX DAYS	RANGE DAYS

> Small sample: 2 verified events. Read these numbers as indicative.

New billable units or mechanisms came with short clocks. Both verified events are from one vendor, DeepSeek, so this category says more about DeepSeek than about the market.

BY VENDOR (DAYS OF NOTICE)

VENDOR	EVENTS	MIN	MEDIAN	MAX
DeepSeek	2	3	8.5	14

NOTABLE EXAMPLES

- **DeepSeek time-of-day pricing.** Announced Aug 13, 2026 and effective Aug 16, 3 days later. This is the same announcement counted as a rate increase above.
- **DeepSeek Search and Fetch.** The tool opened Oct 17, 2026. A fee of 0.75 USD per 1,000 successful requests starts at 00:00 Beijing time on Nov 1 (16:00 UTC Oct 31), 14 days later.

EXCLUDED FROM THE STATISTICS (2)

VENDOR	EVENT	LABEL	WHY
Moonshot	Web Search API pricing	NO EFFECTIVE DATE	Changelog says September 2026 with no day. No effective date stated.
Moonshot	Billing change, 50% cash and 50% voucher deduction	NO EFFECTIVE DATE	Changelog gives the month only (September 2026).

4. Deprecations and Retirements

36	0	95.5	367	367
EVENTS	MIN DAYS	MEDIAN DAYS	MAX DAYS	RANGE DAYS

Retirements are the one category with a real sample. Notice follows each vendor's published policy. OpenAI states at least 6 months for GA models and 3 months for specialized variants. Anthropic states at least 60 days. DeepSeek and Mistral publish no minimum.

BY VENDOR (DAYS OF NOTICE)

VENDOR	EVENTS	MIN	MEDIAN	MAX
Anthropic	8	60	62	189
DeepSeek	3	0	14	91
Mistral	3	1	32	92
OpenAI	22	20	181.5	367

NOTABLE EXAMPLES

- **OpenAI legacy GPT snapshots.** Announced Sep 26, 2025 and retired Sep 28, 2026, 367 days. This is the longest notice in the study.
- **OpenAI gpt-5.4-cyber.** Deprecated Sep 11 and shut down Oct 1, 2026, 20 days. This is the shortest OpenAI notice in the window.
- **Anthropic.** Observed minimum 60 days and median 62 days, in line with its stated 60-day floor. The longest was claude-3-opus at 189 days.
- **Mistral OCR 4.0.** Deprecated Sep 29 and retired Sep 30, 2026, 1 day.
- **DeepSeek deepseek-v4-flash.** Retired Sep 10, 2026, the day it was announced, with the names routed to V4.1-Flash.
- **Moonshot K2 series.** The vendor says it plans to "retire all K2 series models by the end of December 2026" with no date. I excluded it.

EXCLUDED FROM THE STATISTICS (9)

VENDOR	EVENT	LABEL	WHY
Perplexity	Sonar sunset	PROXY ANNOUNCE	Announcement date from my record of the vendor page, not re-fetched Oct 24 (45 days, upper bound).
Moonshot	All K2 series models (kimi-k2.6, kimi-k2.7-code)	NO EFFECTIVE DATE	"By the end of December 2026", no date.

VENDOR	EVENT	LABEL	WHY
Moonshot	kimi-k2.5 and moonshot-v1 series retired	UNVERIFIED ANNOUNCE	Retired 2026-08-31. Announcement date not printed (July changelog closed them to new users only).
Google	gemini-3.5-flash, gemini-3.7-flash delisted and auto-routed	NO EFFECTIVE DATE	Shutdown listed as N/A. Price removed with no notice.
Anthropic	claude-mythos-preview	NO EFFECTIVE DATE	Retirement "To be announced".
xAI	grok-imagine-image-quality	UNVERIFIED ANNOUNCE	Effective 2026-11-02. Announcement date unverified.
xAI	grok-3, grok-4-fast (retired, billed at grok-4.3)	UNVERIFIED ANNOUNCE	Effective 2026-05-15. Announcement date unverified.
Microsoft	Phi-4 family	UNVERIFIED ANNOUNCE	Effective 2027-01-17. Announcement date and first-party URL not captured.
Cohere	Command A and Command R token prices withdrawn	NO EFFECTIVE DATE	No notice and no effective date.

What This Means If You Manage AI Spend

1. **Increases get more notice than decreases.** Every verified decrease took effect the day it was announced (2 of 2). The shortest verified increase was 3 days (DeepSeek). Both Google increases were printed at launch as intro prices with end dates 49 and 121 days out.
2. **Intro prices drive most increases.** Three of the four verified increases are scheduled ends of launch pricing (Google twice, Mistral once). Put every intro end date on your calendar the day a model launches.
3. **New billable mechanisms come fast.** DeepSeek added time-of-day pricing with 3 days of notice and a per-request search fee with 14 days. A weekly price check can miss a 3-day window.
4. **Retirement notice tracks the vendor's published policy.** OpenAI's observed median is 181.5 days with a minimum of 20 days (gpt-5.4-cyber). Anthropic's observed minimum is 60 days and its median is 62. DeepSeek and Mistral, with no published minimum, ran from 0 to 92 days.
5. **Zero-notice events happen.** Anthropic cut a cache-read price on Oct 7, 2026. DeepSeek cut V4.1-Flash prices and retired V4-Flash on Sep 10, 2026. Google delisted gemini-3.5-flash and gemini-3.7-flash prices with no notice and no shutdown date (excluded from the statistics).
6. **Some retirements have no date.** Moonshot says its K2 series goes "by the end of December 2026". Anthropic lists claude-mythos-preview as "to be announced". You cannot schedule around these. You have to watch them.

Methodology

Event universe. First-party changelogs, pricing pages and deprecation pages for OpenAI, Anthropic, Google, DeepSeek, Mistral, Moonshot, xAI, Perplexity, Z.ai, Cohere and Microsoft, plus my own twice-daily Tariff records from Aug 27 to Oct 24, 2026.

Window. June 2025 to October 2026, where vendor pages carry dates.

Dates. The announcement date is the date the vendor printed on the changelog, release note, deprecation entry or pricing page stamp. The effective date is the vendor's stated effective, shutdown or retirement date. Days of notice equal the effective date minus the announcement date, in calendar days, using the date part only (UTC).

Counting. One row per vendor announcement batch. A batch that retires several models on one date counts once.

Exclusions. I left out events with no effective date, events whose announcement date the vendor did not print, and events whose announcement date comes only from my first sighting (marked PROXY ANNOUNCE, an upper bound). Corrections to my own Tariff are not vendor events and are excluded. Only unflagged rows and ZERO NOTICE rows enter the statistics.

Fetch dates. I fetched the OpenAI deprecations, Anthropic model deprecations, Google Gemini deprecations, DeepSeek change log, Mistral changelog and Kimi platform changelog on Oct 24, 2026. Other facts come from dated captures of the vendor page at the time.

Appendix A. Verified Events

Every event that enters the statistics. Days equal the effective date minus the announcement date.

#	CATEGORY	VENDOR	EVENT	ANNOUNCED	EFFECTIVE	DAYS	FLAG
1	Increase	DeepSeek	V4-Pro peak/off-peak repricing (off-peak input 0.435 to 0.66 USD/1M; peak 1.32)	2026-08-13	2026-08-16	3	
2	Increase	Mistral	Mistral Large 4 launch sale (50% off) ends; list 1.36/4.18	2026-10-06	2026-10-20	14	
3	Increase	Google	gemini-4-argon intro ends; 2.00/10.00 to 4.00/20.00	2026-10-13	2026-12-01	49	
4	Increase	Google	gemini-3.8-flash intro ends; 0.75/3.75 to 1.50/7.50	2026-09-02	2027-01-01	121	
8	Decrease	Anthropic	claude-sonnet-5-5 cache read 0.20 to 0.10	2026-10-07	2026-10-07	0	ZERO NOTICE
9	Decrease	DeepSeek	V4.1-Flash release with reduced prices (off-peak 0.15/0.60)	2026-09-10	2026-09-10	0	ZERO NOTICE
11	New element	DeepSeek	Peak/off-peak (time-of-day) pricing introduced	2026-08-13	2026-08-16	3	
12	New element	DeepSeek	Search and Fetch tool fee 0.75 USD per 1,000 successful requests	2026-10-17	2026-10-31	14	
15	Retirement	OpenAI	gpt-4o-realtime-preview-2024-10-01 / gpt-4o-audio-preview-2024-10-01	2025-06-10	2025-10-10	122	
16	Retirement	OpenAI	Assistants API	2025-08-26	2026-08-26	365	
17	Retirement	OpenAI	Realtime API Beta	2025-09-15	2026-05-12	239	
18	Retirement	OpenAI	gpt-4o-realtime-preview family	2025-09-15	2026-05-07	234	
19	Retirement	OpenAI	gpt-4-0314, gpt-4-0125-preview	2025-09-26	2026-03-26	181	
20	Retirement	OpenAI	gpt-3.5-turbo-instruct, babbage-002, davinci-002, gpt-3.5-turbo-1106	2025-09-26	2026-09-28	367	
21	Retirement	OpenAI	dall-e-2, dall-e-3	2025-11-14	2026-05-12	179	
22	Retirement	OpenAI	codex-mini-latest	2025-11-17	2026-02-12	87	
23	Retirement	OpenAI	chatgpt-4o-latest	2025-11-18	2026-02-17	91	
24	Retirement	OpenAI	Sora 2 and Videos API	2026-03-24	2026-09-24	184	
25	Retirement	OpenAI	Legacy snapshots (July batch, incl. gpt-5-codex)	2026-04-22	2026-07-23	92	
26	Retirement	OpenAI	Legacy snapshots (October batch, incl. gpt-4.1-nano, o4-mini, gpt-image-1)	2026-04-22	2026-10-23	184	
27	Retirement	OpenAI	gpt-5.2-chat-latest, gpt-5.3-chat-latest	2026-05-08	2026-08-10	94	
28	Retirement	OpenAI	gpt-image-1-mini, gpt-image-1.5, chatgpt-image-latest	2026-06-02	2026-12-01	182	

#	CATEGORY	VENDOR	EVENT	ANNOUNCED	EFFECTIVE	DAYS	FLAG
29	Retirement	OpenAI	Evals platform, Agent Builder, reusable prompts	2026-06-03	2026-11-30	180	
30	Retirement	OpenAI	gpt-5, gpt-5-mini/nano/pro, o3, o3-pro snapshots	2026-06-11	2026-12-11	183	
31	Retirement	OpenAI	Legacy audio/realtime/transcription families	2026-07-20	2027-01-20	184	
32	Retirement	OpenAI	whisper-1 and gpt-4o transcription models	2026-08-26	2027-02-26	184	
33	Retirement	OpenAI	gpt-5.4-cyber	2026-09-11	2026-10-01	20	
34	Retirement	OpenAI	tts-1, tts-1-hd, gpt-4o-mini-tts	2026-10-01	2027-01-06	97	
35	Retirement	OpenAI	gpt-5.3-codex, gpt-5.1, gpt-5.4-nano	2026-10-01	2027-04-01	182	
36	Retirement	OpenAI	gpt-4o, gpt-4o-mini, gpt-4.1, gpt-4.1-mini	2026-10-14	2027-01-14	92	
37	Retirement	Anthropic	claude-3-opus	2025-06-30	2026-01-05	189	
38	Retirement	Anthropic	claude-3-5-sonnet (both)	2025-08-13	2025-10-28	76	
39	Retirement	Anthropic	claude-3-7-sonnet	2025-10-28	2026-02-19	114	
40	Retirement	Anthropic	claude-3-5-haiku	2025-12-19	2026-02-19	62	
41	Retirement	Anthropic	claude-3-haiku	2026-02-19	2026-04-20	60	
42	Retirement	Anthropic	claude-sonnet-4, claude-opus-4	2026-04-14	2026-06-15	62	
43	Retirement	Anthropic	claude-opus-4-1	2026-06-05	2026-08-05	61	
44	Retirement	Anthropic	claude-sonnet-4-5	2026-09-30	2026-11-30	61	
45	Retirement	DeepSeek	deepseek-v3.2-speciale temporary endpoint	2025-12-01	2025-12-15	14	
46	Retirement	DeepSeek	deepseek-chat / deepseek-reasoner names	2026-04-24	2026-07-24	91	
47	Retirement	DeepSeek	deepseek-v4-flash and v4-flash-vision-exp retired (names routed to V4.1-Flash)	2026-09-10	2026-09-10	0	ZERO NOTICE
48	Retirement	Mistral	labs-leanstral-1-5 (retirement stated at release)	2026-06-30	2026-09-30	92	
49	Retirement	Mistral	mistral-ocr-4-0	2026-09-29	2026-09-30	1	
50	Retirement	Mistral	zai-glm-5-2 (hosted on Mistral)	2026-09-29	2026-10-31	32	

Appendix B. Sources

SOURCE	URL	DATE
OpenAI deprecations	https://platform.openai.com/docs/deprecations	Fetched 2026-10-24
Anthropic model deprecations	https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/about-claude/model-deprecations	Fetched 2026-10-24
Anthropic release notes	https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/release-notes/overview	Entry Oct 7, 2026, captured 2026-10-08

SOURCE	URL	DATE
Google Gemini deprecations	https://ai.google.dev/gemini-api/docs/deprecations	Fetched 2026-10-24
Google Gemini pricing	https://ai.google.dev/gemini-api/docs/pricing	Captured 2026-09-02 and 2026-10-14
DeepSeek change log	https://api-docs.deepseek.com/updates/	Fetched 2026-10-24
DeepSeek pricing	https://api-docs.deepseek.com/quick_start/pricing	Captured 2026-10-18 to 2026-10-23
Mistral changelog	https://docs.mistral.ai/getting-started/changelog	Fetched 2026-10-24
Kimi platform changelog	https://platform.kimi.ai/docs/platform-changelog	Fetched 2026-10-24
Kimi models	https://platform.kimi.ai/docs/models	Captured 2026-10-23
Z.ai pricing	https://docs.z.ai/guides/overview/pricing	Captured 2026-08-29
Perplexity Sonar	https://docs.perplexity.ai/docs/sonar/models/sonar	Captured Aug to Sep 2026
xAI models	https://docs.x.ai/developers/models	Captured 2026-08-28
Cohere pricing	https://cohere.com/pricing	Captured 2026-10-22
Anthropic pricing (tokenizer note)	https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/about-claude/pricing	Fetched 2026-10-24, via The 28 Ways AI Models Charge
The 28 Ways AI Models Charge (28 mechanisms, 106 models, 18 vendors)	https://jerrywlambert.com/briefings/28-ways-ai-gets-billed/	Jerry W. Lambert, Sr., Oct 24, 2026

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